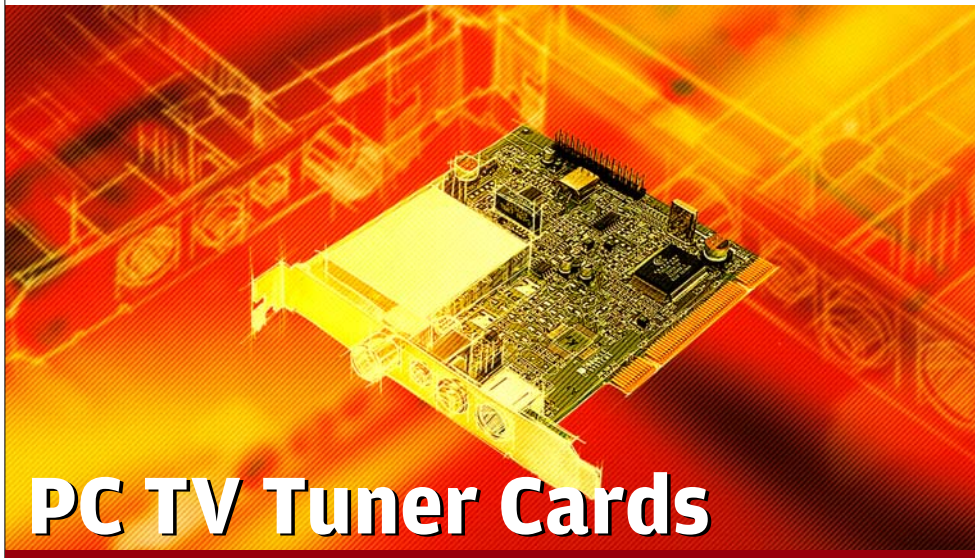




PC TV Tuner Cards

PC TV concepts have been popular right from the day they were introduced. The products available then offered very few features, and software support was limited to the bundled software.

However, as it stands today, the hardware has improved to an extent that there is a no difference between watching a program on TV or on a computer screen. On the software side, the bundled software offers complete PVR solutions, enabling most users to schedule recordings of their favourite programs in digital format for later viewing.

It's heartening to see industry big guns such as Microsoft and Intel backing the digital home concept with a slew of products that enhance the media-centric capabilities of your PC. Media-centric support down to the OS level means

tight integration of the entire package. TV tuner cards are an important component of the media-centric concept, and hence, in the near future, you may even be able to tune into high definition video on your desktop.

Components Of A TV Tuner Card

RF Tuner: This is the heart of the TV tuner card, and it helps in tuning to a particular TV station. The signal coming from your cable operator or antenna is supplied to the RF tuner.

ADC: The Analogue to Digital Converter, this piece of circuitry converts the analogue signals coming from your cable to digital signals that a computer can understand and process.

FM antenna connector: Generally seen on the back

Ready Reckoner	
 You Need	A TV tuner card with a basic feature set and does not cost too much
Look for	An entry-level TV tuner card that offers 100 channels, and provides a remote control
 You Need	A card with added features such as PVR functionality, FM tuner, video capture etc.
Look for	A TV tuner from the upper segment of the market; it will cost no more than Rs 3000
 You Need	Advanced capturing functionality from DV-Cams, VCR's etc
Look for	capturing capabilities, S-Video IN, S-Video Out, FireWire connectivity



panel of the card, you connect the provided FM antenna to this connector.

Cable TV Connector: You connect an incoming signal source, such as a cable TV cable, to this connector, which in turn feeds the RF tuner for synthesis.

IR Port: The IR receiver required for the remote control to operate is connected to this connector on the back panel.

S-Video and Composite Inputs: These ports are used for connecting other video devices such as a VCR or handycam, and come in handy for content capturing.

Audio connectors: These connectors are connected to the respective connectors of your sound card for audio playback.

Buying Tips

- ✓ You get two types of TV tuners—internal cards and external boxes. Internal cards are plugged into your system; external boxes can be used without switching on your PC.
- ✓ Internal cards are good when you want to capture live programs, which most external boxes do not allow.
- ✓ Casual gamers who want a TV tuner card can invest in the all-in-one solutions that have cropped up in recent times.
- ✓ If you listen to the radio, buy a TV tuner that has an inbuilt FM receiver.
- ✓ Make sure the device you buy offers features such as time shifting, scheduled recording and image capture; they are

extremely useful when recording a program.

- ✓ Some high end TV tuners allow capturing of video from handycams and other analogue devices, which is converted to digital format. If you have a handycam, it would be advisable to invest in such a card.
- ✓ Before you buy a new TV tuner card, make sure it is compatible with your display card. Motherboards with older Savage 3D video controllers may require a driver update, or a new video card.
- ✓ If you plan to capture live programs, make sure your audio drivers are updated to the latest versions. Older versions might result in cracking of sound.